

Sin As Transgression

doc-sin-as-transgression
Hamartiology · Definition of Sin · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Sin is any want of conformity to, or transgression of, the law of God (in thought, word, deed, and disposition) and is fundamentally an offense against God's holy character, not merely against neighbour.

In plain language

The claim lines up with the words across both testaments, with one fair qualification. In 1 John 3:4 the apostle writes that everyone who does sin also does lawlessness, then caps the sentence with a near equation, sin is lawlessness. In Greek both nouns carry the article 'the', so the sentence reads almost like an identity, and the word for lawlessness, 'lawlessness' (anomia), is simply 'law' (nomos) with a negating prefix, so its very shape ties sin to violating God's law. Paul develops the same picture in Romans 7, using the same word for sin and binding it to commandment and to law. He says he would not have known sin except through the law, and he calls the commandment holy and just and good, so sin is opposition to a standard that carries God's own character. James calls the person who breaks one command a 'transgressor of law' (parabates nomou), using a word that pictures stepping over a marked line, and James 4:17 widens sin to include knowing the right and not doing it. So far the law centered reading is very strong. The fair qualification is that the wider family of sin words reaches past breaking a written rule. The Greek word for sin, 'sin' (hamartia), at root means failure or missing, the Hebrew words 'iniquity' (avon) and 'rebellion' (pesha) mean iniquity, guilt, and rebellion against a person, and Romans 3:23 says all have sinned and fall short ('falling short', hystereo) of the glory of God, measuring sin against God himself rather than a statute. Romans 4:15 says where there is no law there is no 'transgression' (parabasis), and Romans 5:13 says sin was in the world before the law though it was not formally counted, which shows that sin is real and broader than the narrower idea of breaking a specific rule. Psalm 51 places sin vertically, against you only have I sinned, using the verb 'to miss' (chata). This is why thoughtful readers can land in slightly different places, some make breaking God's law the core meaning, others make offending God himself the core and treat rule breaking as one form of it. The proposition states both, want of conformity or transgression of the law, and fundamentally an offense against God, so on either reading it is affirmed.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H2398	חַטָּא	chata	to sin	223
H2403	חַטָּאת	chattat	sin	280
H5771	אָוֹן	avon	iniquity	203
H6588	פֶּשַׁע	pesha	transgression	81
G0018	ἀγαθός	agathos	good	

G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	174
G0268	ἁμαρτωλός	hamartolos	sinful	48
G0458	ἀνομία	anomia	lawlessness	16
G0874	ἀφορμή	aphormē	opportunity	
G1342	δίκαιος	dikaios	just	
G1777	ἐνοχος	enochos	liable for	10
G1785	ἐντολή	entole	commandment	69
G1818	ἐξαπατάω	exapatao	to deceive	6
G1939	ἐπιθυμία	epithumia	desire	38
G3431	μοιχεύω	moicheuo	to commit adultery	15
G3551	νόμος	nomos	law	196
G3845	παραβαίνω	parabainō	to transgress	
G3847	παράβασις	parabasis	transgression	7
G3848	παραβάτης	parabates	transgressor	5
G3892	παρὰνομία	paranomia	lawlessness	
G5302	ὑστερέω	hystereo	to lack	16
G5407	φονεύω	phoneuo	to murder	12

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern across both testaments grounds sin in violation of God's revealed law and in offense against God himself, and the proposition fairly captures both dimensions by saying want of conformity OR transgression of the law and fundamentally an offense against God. 1 John 3:4 supplies a near-equation, 'and the sin is the lawlessness' (kai he hamartia estin he anomia), that is, sin is lawlessness, with the article 'the' on both nouns making it a convertible identity (an 'A is B' statement that runs equally well as 'B is A'), and 'lawlessness' (anomia) is the alpha-privative (the form that prefixes a negating 'not-') of 'law' (nomos), so it is law-relative by construction. Romans 7:7-13 binds 'sin' (hamartia) causally to 'commandment' (entole) and 'law' (nomos), the commandment exposes sin. James 2:9-11 names the offender 'transgressor of law' (parabates nomou). Psalm 51:4 pairs the Hebrew sin-nouns 'iniquity' (avon) and 'sin' (chattat). The one honest nuance is that the wider vocabulary, 'sin' (hamartia) as failure or missing, the relational 'rebellion' (pesha), 'iniquity or guilt' (avon), and 'falling short' (hystereo) of God's glory in Romans 3:23, shows sin to be broader than legal transgression alone. Romans 5:13 makes this explicit, sin was in the world before the law but is not counted where there is no law, distinguishing 'sin' (hamartia) from the narrower law-relative 'transgression' (parabasis). Transgression of law is thus one true and central definition within a broader semantic field, which is exactly what the proposition states.

Scripture

1John.3.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία, G0458 ἀνομία

Reasoning. Defining clausal equation. The full text reads 'and the sin is the lawlessness' (kai he hamartia estin he anomia), that is, sin is lawlessness. Both the subject 'the sin' (he hamartia) and the predicate 'the lawlessness' (he anomia) carry the article 'the', which yields a convertible identity (the statement reads equally as 'sin is lawlessness' and 'lawlessness is sin') rather than a one-way class statement. The participial clause 'the one doing the sin' (ho poion ten hamartian) is paired with 'does the lawlessness' (ten anomian poiei). The alpha-privative (the prefix that negates) on 'law' (nomos) in 'lawlessness' (anomia) makes the relation to law constitutive, not incidental. This is the single most equation-like sentence in the canon on what sin is.

Rom.7.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία, G3551 νόμος, G1939 ἐπιθυμία

Reasoning. Paul's rhetorical question 'is the law sin?' (ho nomos hamartia) and the answer 'may it never be!' (me genoito) tie sin and law together causally rather than by identity. The clause 'I would not have known the sin except through law' (ten hamartian ouk egnon ei me dia nomou) says sin would have been unknown apart from the law, then he names the Decalogue (Ten Commandments) commandment 'you shall not covet' (ouk epithumeseis) as the diagnostic instrument. Sin is what the law exposes and forbids, and 'desire' or 'covetous craving' (epithumia) shows the inward dispositional reach.

Rom.7.8 · for · genre: epistle · figures: personification

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία, G1785 ἐντολή, G0874 ἀφορμή

Reasoning. 'Sin' (hamartia) is personified as an agent that takes 'a starting point' or 'a base of operations' (aphorme) through the 'commandment' (entole) and 'produced' or 'worked out' (kateirgasato) every kind of 'covetous desire' (epithumia). Without 'law' (nomos), 'sin' (hamartia) is 'dead' (nekra). The grammar makes the commandment the operative reference point for the activity called sin, but the clause 'apart from law sin is dead' (choris nomou hamartia nekra) concerns sin's recognizable activity, not the bare existence of sin.

Rom.7.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G1785 ἐντολή, G0018 ἀγαθός, G1342 δίκαιος

Reasoning. The triple predication 'holy and just and good' (hagia kai dikaia kai agathe) on the 'commandment' (entole), and 'holy' (hagios) on the 'law' (nomos), situates sin as opposition to a law that bears God's own moral character. Sin's offense is therefore not horizontal only, the standard violated belongs to God.

Rom.7.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία, G1785 ἐντολή

Reasoning. Paul drives the definition home, 'that sin might become exceedingly sinful through the commandment' (hina genetai kath hyperbolen hamartolos he hamartia dia tes entoles), that sin through the commandment might become exceedingly sinful. The 'commandment' (entole) is what shows sin to be sin in its true character. Sin is named relationally to revealed command.

Jas.2.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G1777 ἔνοχος

Reasoning. 'Whoever keeps the whole law but stumbles in one point has become guilty of all' (Hostis holon ton nomon terese, ptaise de en heni, gegonen panton enochos). The legal adjective 'liable' or 'guilty' (enochos) ties guilt to the unity of God's 'law' (nomos), not to discrete social harms. Sin is configured as failure against an integral law.

Jas.2.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3431 μοιχεύω, G5407 φονεύω, G3848 παραβάτης

Reasoning. James identifies the lawgiver as the one who said both 'do not commit adultery' (me moicheuses) and 'do not murder' (me phoneuses), then names the offender 'transgressor of law' (parabates nomou). The noun 'transgressor' (parabates) derives from 'to step beside or across' (parabaino), picturing crossing a defined boundary. The companion verse James 2:9 already labels the offender 'transgressor' (parabates) under the law. Sin is configured here as transgression of God's spoken command.

Jas.4.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία

Reasoning. 'To one therefore knowing to do good and not doing it, to him it is sin' (Eidoti oun kalon poiein kai me poiounti, hamartia auto estin). The omission and dispositional dimension is named directly, sin is not limited to overt acts or to formal code-breaking, yet it stays within the same lexical family 'sin' (hamartia).

Ps.51.4 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H5771 יָנַח, H2403 נָחַח

Reasoning. In the Masoretic verse numbering the petition reads 'wash me thoroughly from my iniquity and cleanse me from my sin' (kabbeseni me-avoni u-me-chattati tahareni). The two sin-nouns 'iniquity' (avon) and 'sin' (chattat) stand in parallel cola (matched poetic lines), governed by imperative verbs (command-form verbs) that ETCBC (the Hebrew syntax database) marks as imperative clauses. ETCBC glosses both nouns as sin. The adjacent verse Psalm 51:6 in Masoretic numbering supplies the vertical clause 'against you, you only, have I sinned' (lekha lebadkha chatati), using the verb 'to miss' (chata), with God as the sole offended party. The nominal pair here and the vertical verb there together anchor sin as both a real condition and an offense against God.

Rom.5.13 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία, G3551 νόμος

Reasoning. 'For until the law sin was in the world, but sin is not counted when there is no law' (Achri gar nomou hamartia en en kosmoi, hamartia de ouk ellogeitai me ontos nomou). Until the law sin was in the world, but sin is not counted where there is no law. The clause distinguishes the existence of 'sin' (hamartia), present before the law, from its being reckoned or charged, which is law-relative. This shows the sin-vocabulary is broader than the law-relative transgression-words, while still affirming that law is what formally reckons sin.

Rom.3.23 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία, G5302 ὑστερέω

Reasoning. 'For all sinned and fall short of the glory of God' (Pantes gar hemarton kai hystereountai tes doxes tou theou). All sinned and fall short of the glory of God. The verb of sinning 'they sinned' (hemarton) stands beside 'fall short' or 'lack' (hystereo), and the deficiency is measured against the glory of God, not against a written statute. This expresses the broad failing-short dimension of sin alongside the law-relative dimension.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1John.3.4	1John.5.17	openbible	31
1John.3.4	Rom.3.20	openbible	25
1John.3.4	Rom.4.15	openbible	21
1John.3.4	Num.15.31	openbible	20
1John.3.4	Jas.2.9	openbible	15
Rom.5.13	Rom.4.15	openbible	18

Rom.5.13	1John.3.4	openbible	6
Rom.4.15	Rom.5.13	openbible	19
Rom.4.15	Gal.3.19	openbible	7
Jas.2.10	Gal.3.10	openbible	39
Jas.2.10	Deut.27.26	openbible	18
Jas.2.11	Exod.20.13	openbible	13
Jas.2.11	Rom.13.9	openbible	4
Ps.51.4	2Sam.12.13	openbible	15
Ps.51.4	Rom.3.4	openbible	9
Rom.3.23	Eccl.7.20	openbible	243
Rom.3.23	1John.1.8	openbible	145
1John.3.4	1John.3.8	tsk	1
Jas.2.11	Lev.4.2	tsk	1
Rom.7.9	Rom.3.19	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Rom.7.7 · addressed

Paul's question 'is the law sin?' (ho nomos hamartia) is rhetorical and answered 'may it never be!' (me genoito). The verse does not equate law with sin, it asserts the law's diagnostic role. The flow Romans 7:7-13 culminates in Romans 7:12 where the law is 'holy' (hagios) and the 'commandment' (entole) is 'holy and just and good' (hagia kai dikaia kai agathe), so sin is opposition to a good law, not the law itself.

Rom.5.13 · addressed

Sin was in the world before the law but is not counted where there is no law. This does not falsify 1 John 3:4, it refines it. The 'sin equals lawlessness' (hamartia-anomia) equation in 1 John concerns sin's defining character in relation to God's revealed will, while Paul's clause concerns formal reckoning, which is law-relative. The text shows 'sin' (hamartia) is broader than the narrower law-relative 'transgression' (parabasis), which is why the proposition correctly speaks of want of conformity OR transgression, not transgression alone.

Rom.3.23 · addressed

Falling short of the glory of God, 'falling short' (hystereo), names sin relationally against God's glory rather than against a statute. This broadens the field beyond formal code-breaking but stays inside the same sin-vocabulary, 'they sinned' (hemarton), and supports the proposition's clause that sin is fundamentally an offense against God's holy character, not merely against neighbour.

Rom.4.15 · addressed

'Where there is no law, neither is there transgression' (Hou de ouk estin nomos, oude parabasis). The transgression-word 'transgression' (parabasis) is strictly law-relative, which is why the broader word 'sin' (hamartia), not 'transgression' (parabasis), carries the cases where sin precedes or exceeds a written code. This delimits the scope of the transgression term without weakening the affirmation.

Concordance traversed

G0266, G0458, G3551, G1785, G3847, G3848, G3845, G0268, G1777, G3431, G5407, G1818, G1939, G5302, G3892, H2403, H5771, H6588, H2398

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant unit in the ingested data for 1 John 3:4, Romans 7:7-13, Romans 5:13, Romans 4:15, Romans 3:23, James 2:9-11, James 4:17, or Psalm 51:4 would alter the lexical equation 'sin equals lawlessness' (hamartia equals anomia), the 'transgression' (parabasis) and 'transgressor' (parabates) terminology, or the Hebrew 'iniquity' (avon) and 'sin' (chattat) pair. None of the anchors fall in the ingested ECM apparatus window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) of 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, so CBGM (the coherence-based genealogical method used in modern textual criticism) was not engaged. The verdict holds in the SBLGNT (the SBL Greek New Testament) and Nestle1904 (the 1904 Nestle Greek New Testament) readings present in the store.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. law_relative_definition, relational_covenantal_definition

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

law_relative_definition: affirms · Reading sin primarily as transgression of God's revealed law, the lexical case is strong and direct. 1 John 3:4 equates 'the sin' (he hamartia) with 'the lawlessness' (he anomia), 'lawlessness' (anomia) being the alpha-privative (the negating prefix form) of 'law' (nomos). James 2:11 calls the offender 'transgressor of law' (parabates nomou). Romans 7 binds 'sin' (hamartia) to 'commandment' (entole) and 'law' (nomos). On this lens the central and definitive sense of sin is conformity-failure against a law that bears God's holy character.

relational_covenantal_definition: affirms_with_nuance · Reading sin primarily as a relational and covenantal breach against God's person, this lens is also well supported and is represented here in its strongest form. The Hebrew 'rebellion' (pesha) means rebellion against a covenant partner, 'iniquity' (avon) means perversity, iniquity, and guilt, and the verb 'to miss' (chata) in Psalm 51:6 makes God the sole offended party, against you, you only. In Romans 3:23 sin is 'falling short' (hystereo), falling short of the glory of God, and Romans 5:13 says sin existed before the law though not formally counted. On this lens transgression of a specific statute is one true expression of sin, but the deeper category is offense against God himself, which the broader 'sin' (hamartia), 'iniquity' (avon), and 'rebellion' (pesha) vocabulary carries. This lens does not deny the law-relative definition, it embeds it inside a wider relational one, and the proposition's own wording, want of conformity OR transgression and fundamentally an offense against God, honours both.

The two lenses are not contradictory and both affirm the proposition. They differ only on which sense is primary and which is derived. Hebrew poetic parallelism between 'iniquity' (avon) and 'sin' (chattat) in Psalm 51:4 reinforces the nominal sin-vocabulary, but the figures list stays empty because parallelism is not in the enum (the fixed set of allowed labels), the parallelism is described in the force field instead.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition is detailed but its claims map onto real lexical data rather than a tradition-specific taxonomy. Want of conformity and transgression map to 1 John 3:4 'sin equals lawlessness' (hamartia equals anomia) and to James 2:11 'transgressor of law' (parabates nomou). Thought, word, deed, and disposition map to James 4:17 omission and Romans 7:7 'covetous desire' (epithumia). Offense against God's holy character, not merely against neighbour, maps to Romans 7:12 the law as holy and just and good, to Psalm 51:6 against you only, and to Romans 3:23 falling short of God's glory. The phrase any want of conformity to OR transgression of is itself the disjunction (the 'either-or' choice) that keeps the stem from over-narrowing sin to legal transgression, so no neutralization is required. The verdict is derived on the original stem. The prior evidence attached the gloss against you only have I sinned to Psalm 51:4, but in the store and Masoretic numbering that clause sits at Psalm 51:6 and uses the verb 'to miss' (chata), while Psalm 51:4 carries the noun pair 'iniquity' (avon) and 'sin' (chattat). This file corrects that placement, which does not change the verdict.

Citations

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interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1John.3.4
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.7.7
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.5.13

interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.3.23
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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.3.4
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morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.51.4
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0266
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0458
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3847
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5302
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1777
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2403
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5771
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6588
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.51.4
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.51.6
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1John.3.4
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.5.13
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Flags

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